

Music on the Go

Nothing can upstage the pleasure of listening to your favourite tunes while you are stuck in bumper-to-bumper traffic.

If your car deck has a Line In port, connecting an MP3 player to your car deck is just a matter of getting a 3.5 mm stereo cable and plugging it in. Connect the red and white RCA connectors to the car deck and the single pin connector to your MP3 player's Line Out or earphone jack. If the audio system in your car does not have a Line In function, you can buy a car MP3 adapter from the market. This adapter looks exactly like a cassette



with the connection port on one end where the stereo cable is connected, while the other end goes in the earphone jack on the MP3 player. The trade off here is that the sound quality will not be so good because of the magnetic coupling between the adapter head and car audio system's head. The magnetic interference will produce noise and hence a loss in sound quality, but hey, it still beats cassettes!



service centres appointed by their companies and the number of cities in which the centres are present.

Value for money: This provides us with a price-performance ratio—a player offering good performance at a reasonable price will score higher in this category than one offering excellent performance with a hefty price tag.

How They Fared

We tested six MP3 players from vendors such as Creative Labs and D-Link Corp. We based our evaluation on criteria ranging from the features that a portable player supports (like the ability to play both MP3 and WMA files), to its performance (audio quality and battery life).

Features

Being a portable device, the playtime that an MP3 player offers becomes crucial—a longer battery life will keep the device going and will ease the burden on your wallet as you won't have to repeatedly buy batteries. Of course, if the player comes with a set of rechargeable batteries like the NAPA DAV316, there is nothing like it. Finally, as a general rule, solid-state devices consume less power than CD-based solutions on account of the absence of any moving parts.

The second most important trait is the space offered to store the music files. CD-based players rule the roost in this regard, since a CD can store up to 700 MB of compressed files. If you are looking for a CD-driven solution, make sure that it has electronic shock protection. The models that we tested, for example, all sported a 120 second buffer, which allowed them to play songs without skipping, while travelling.

In the case of a solid-state player, the question of future

upgrades comes into play—the D-Link DMP-100, for example offers a SmartMedia external module and the Creative PA-20 can be upgraded from its internal 32 MB memory to a maximum of 96 MB. Ensure that the MP3 player supports at least one of the standard audio formats, viz. MP3 and WMA, or preferably both like the Creative PA-20. As a rule, a CD-based player will play both MP3 and audio CDs.

Most of the solid state devices use a USB port to transfer songs to and from the computer, the D-Link DMP-100 being the only exception. A USB port is, of course, not essential for the CD-based devices, but the extra cost of a CD-Writer that will be needed to create those MP3 CDs should be considered.

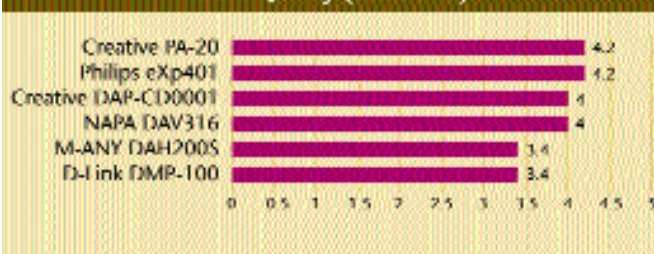
A cool thing to have in a portable device is a manual equalizer. Alas, none of the products we tested had them, though some did come with preset-equalizer modes that let you choose between settings such as Pop, Jazz, Rock, etc—the D-Link player being one such solution.

An MP3 player would not be half as useful if it did not allow you to customise your favourite tracks. A good player should support creation of customised playlists, editing of playlists and should feature a track browser, to let you choose and select a song from within a list. Moreover, an ability to randomise a list of songs or to get a 10-second preview of all the songs within a list is considered a bonus. The Creative DAP-CD0001 supports all these essentials, whereas the M-ANY DAH2005 does not feature even one.

Ease of use and ergonomics

Ergonomics plays an equally important role in the buying decision, as do features. Portability, placement of buttons and ease of navigation are important pieces that fall in to create the perfect MP3 player. Thus, while evaluating the contenders, we first looked at whether the buttons were well within reach or were put in places that are hard to get at. The Creative DAP-CD0001 and the NAPA DAV316 had the buttons placed in a most logical way, most of them occupying the front panel. We also determined the ease with which a player lets you navigate its menu structure. The Creative DAP-CD0001 again scored high points

Audio Quality (Scale of 5)



Battery Life (in minutes)

